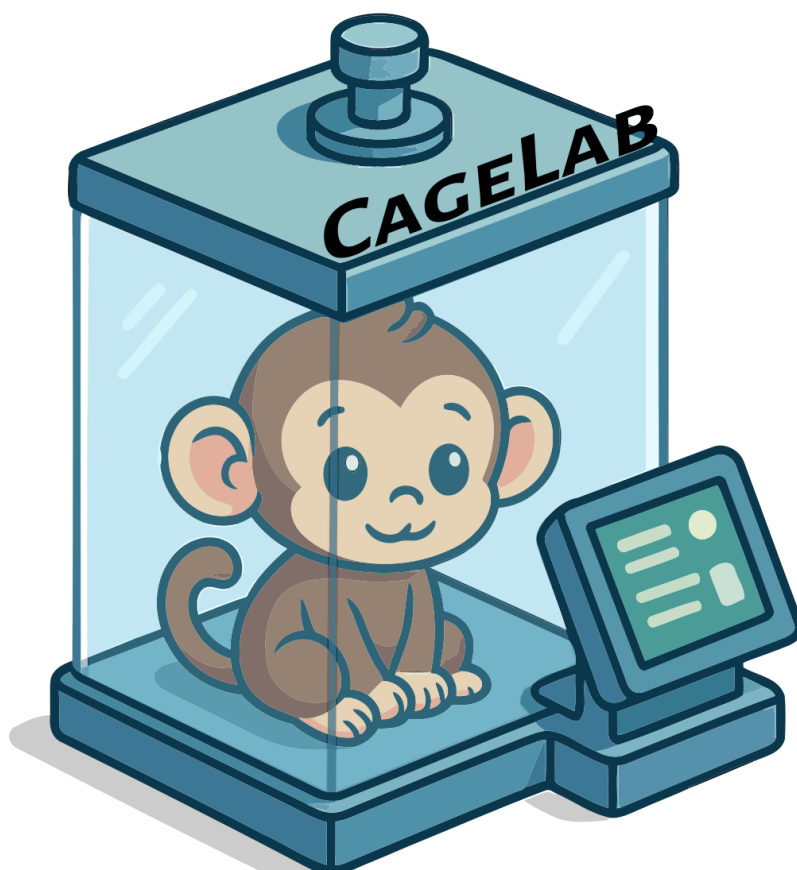

CageLab User Guide

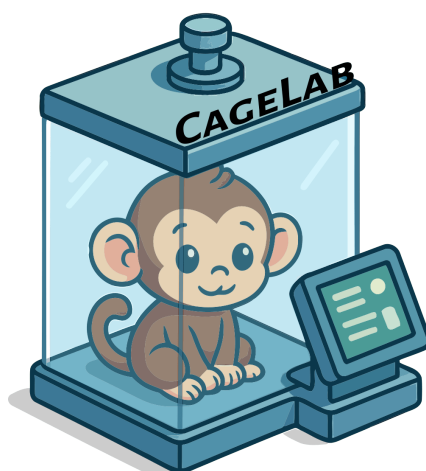
First edition

CageLab Development Team



CageLab User Guide

First edition



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Chapter 1

Introduction

CageLab is a modular, network-distributed system for running remote neuroscience behavioural experiments. It separates the **Control-PC** (the experimenter's workstation, usually in an office) from the **CageLab-Box** (the cage-attached computer driving stimuli, touch, reward, and video recording), allowing a single researcher to manage many subjects across multiple cages from one place.

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1.1. The Big Picture

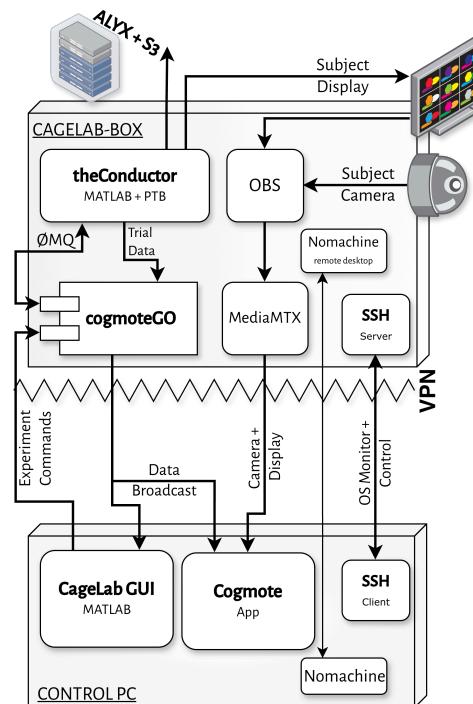


Figure 1.1 – Main software components for Control and Communication

CageLab is a combination of hardware and software. The software uses several core software components, connected over a local network or VPN.

The system is built on three principles:

1. **Distributed architecture** — the experimenter designs tasks and monitors behaviour from their Control-PC; the CageLab-Box runs the experiment locally with deterministic timing via Psychtoolbox (PTB). If necessary a researcher can run the control interface and experiment from the same system (useful for debugging & development for example, or if there is no Control-PC available).
2. **HTTP API + ØMQ bridge** — all external commands from the Control-PC arrive via cogmoteGO's HTTP REST API; internally, cogmoteGO bridges these commands to theConductor over a local ZeroMQ (ØMQ) connection.
3. **Automation-first** — Ansible playbooks bootstrap, update, and maintain groups of CageLab-Boxes simultaneously; systemd services keep critical processes alive and self-healing.

1.2. Key Components at a Glance

Table 1.1 – Key components

Component	Role	Language	Runs On
CageLab GUI	Experiment design, control, and monitoring	MATLAB	Control-PC
cogmoteGO	HTTP API / ØMQ bridge, WebRTC streaming	Go	CageLab-Box
theConductor	ØMQ REP server, receives commands and launches tasks	MATLAB	CageLab-Box
+cltasks	Behavioural task library (MTS, IED, Oddball, etc.)	MATLAB	CageLab-Box
OBS Studio	Video recording of experimental sessions	C++ (Flatpak)	CageLab-Box
MediaMTX	RTSP/WebRTC media server for low-latency streaming	Go	CageLab-Box
SSH	remote access,	System	Control-PC
Ansible	Group automation, updates, and maintenance	Python	Control-PC
NetBird	WireGuard-based VPN mesh for cross-site connectivity	Go	Both

1.3. Architecture Deep-Dive: HTTP API + ØMQ Bridge

cogmoteGO exposes two interfaces:

- **External:** an HTTP REST API on port 9012, used by the Control-PC (CageLab GUI, curl, Ansible). Full API documentation: cogmotego.apifox.cn/.
- **Internal:** a local ØMQ connection to theConductor, used only within the CageLab-Box.

The communication stack works as follows:

1. cogmoteGO starts first, binding its HTTP API on port 9012 and preparing an internal ØMQ channel for local communication.
2. theConductor starts next. It opens a **REP** ØMQ socket on port 6666 and calls cogmoteGO's HTTP API (POST /api/cmds/proxies) to register itself as a **command proxy** named **matlab**. This tells cogmoteGO where to forward incoming commands.
3. A handshake occurs: cogmoteGO sends {"request": "Hello"} over the local ØMQ channel; theConductor responds {"response": "World"}. The proxy is now active.
4. When the Control-PC sends a command (e.g., to run a task), it POSTs JSON to cogmoteGO's HTTP API. cogmoteGO bridges the command to theConductor via the internal ØMQ proxy, waits for the reply, and returns it as the HTTP response.
5. theConductor's process() loop polls the ØMQ socket for incoming messages, dispatches commands (run, echo, gettime, commandlist, etc.), and sends structured replies back through the proxy.

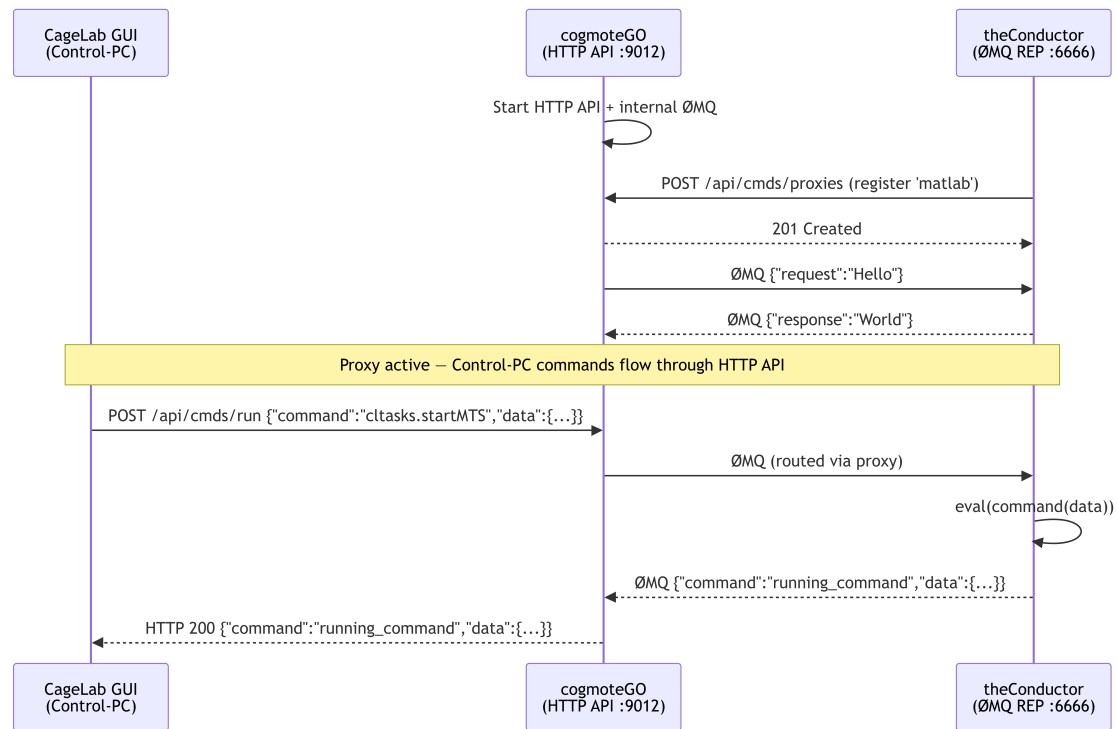


Figure 1.2 – Message Passing

1.4. Supported Hardware

- **Touchscreens:** ILITEK-TP (tested) and other X11-compatible touch panels (controlled via `toggleInput` and `touchManager`)
- **Reward Pumps:** PTBSimia-managed peristaltic/syringe pumps
- **Audio:** Standard sound cards via Opticka's `audioManager`
- **Camera:** Anything compatible with OBS Studio (hardware-accelerated encoding (VA-API/NVENC))
- **Screens:** Standard 60–240 Hz LCD/OLED panels or dedicated research panels via DisplayPort/HDMI (FreeSync/G-Sync compatible) thanks to PTB.

Chapter 2

Dependencies & Installing

This chapter covers software installation for both the **CageLab-Box** (the remote experiment computer/kiosk) and the **Control-PC** (the researcher's workstation).

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2.1. Software Stack Overview

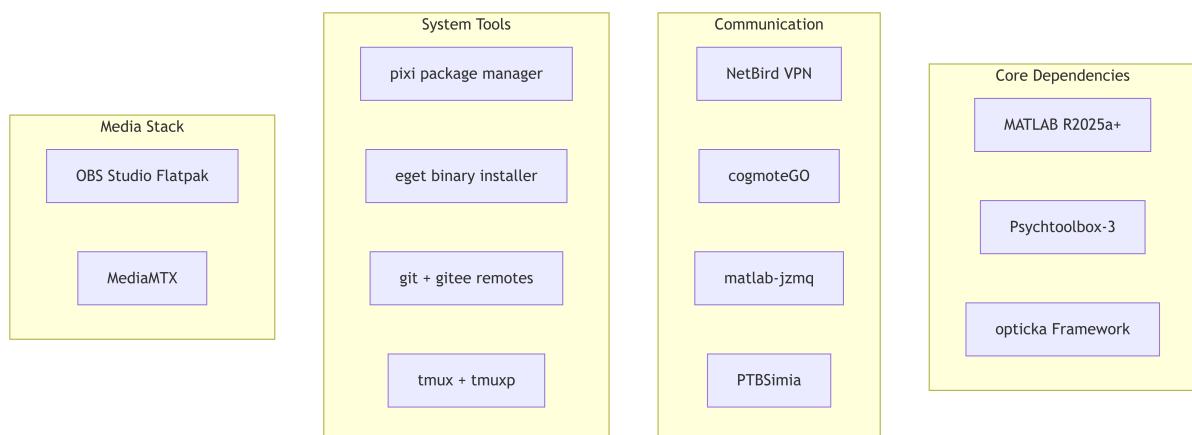


Figure 2.1 – Installation requirements

2.2. CageLab-Box Installation

The CageLab-Box runs **Ubuntu Linux** (24.04 LTS or later) with the **i3 window manager** for a min-

imal, uncomposited X11 environment that has two benefits: (1) PTB timing precision is improved¹; (2) i3 has no touchable GUI, stopping subjects from manipulating any desktop widgets when no task is running.

2.2.1. Step 1: Bootstrap

For a fresh system, we have a bootstrap script that will install dependencies and set up the correct file locations. Clone the CageLab-Code repository and run the bootstrap script:

```
mkdir -p ~/Code
cd ~/Code
git clone --recurse-submodules https://gitee.com/CogPlatform/CageLab-Code.git
cd CageLab-Code/setup
./bootstrap.sh
```

The bootstrap script performs the following: - Installs essential APT packages (git, curl, zsh, i3, tmux, flatpak, etc.) - Installs pixi (cross-platform package manager) - Installs NetBird VPN - Optionally: installs MATLAB via MathWorks Package Manager (MPM) - Installs cogmoteG0 via its install script - Installs NoMachine remote desktop - Installs eget and MediaMTX - Clones all core repositories from Gitee - Sets up the PTB/Opticka MATLAB path - Runs makelinks.sh to symlink scripts, configs, and systemd services

2.2.2. Step 2: Run makelinks.sh

It is recommended to regularly run makelinks.sh, and especially after any code changes:

For CageLab:

```
~/Code/CageLab-Code/setup/makelinks.sh
```

For Control-PC:

```
~/Code/CageLab-Code/setup/makelinks.sh -c
```

This symlinks ZSH configs, script files, systemd services, SSH config, i3 config, tmux config, and the pixi manifest. Use the -c flag for Control-PC to ensure Ansible config is correctly linked.

2.2.3. Step 3: Verify Services on CageLab

```
systemctl --user status cogmoteG0.service
systemctl --user status theConductor.service
systemctl --user status mediamtx.service
systemctl --user status obs.service
```

2.3. Control-PC Installation

On the Control-PC, you can install the same services as CageLab-Box if you want to perform any testing, however in general these are not necessary. We use Ubuntu, and our scripts are designed for Posix systems (any Linux, macOS), so some scripts will need to be modified (or run using WSL) on Windows. Running Linux everywhere makes problem solving a bit smoother, and gets stuff used to Linux and thus able to better support the remote system. You typically need:

1. **MATLAB** with the same toolboxes as the CageLab-Box (Curve Fitting, Instrument Control, Optimization, Parallel Computing, Signal Processing, Statistics and Machine Learning).

¹Composited desktop environments (GNOME, KDE) introduce unpredictable frame drops and timing jitter. i3 is a tiling window manager with no compositor, ensuring PTB can take full control of the display.

2. **The CageLab GUI** (part of CageLab-Code, running inside MATLAB).

3. **Ansible** for group management:

```
uv tool install ansible
ansible-galaxy collection install ansible.posix
```

4. **SSH keys** configured for Control-PC and each CageLab-Box (see [Network Setup]).

2.3.1. MATLAB Dependencies

Most of these MATLAB toolboxes are not strictly required but recommended for full CageLab operation:

Table 2.1 – MATLAB toolboxes

Toolbox	Purpose
MATLAB	Core runtime
Curve Fitting Toolbox	Data fitting for analysis
Instrument Control Toolbox	Hardware communication
Optimization Toolbox	Parameter optimization
Parallel Computing Toolbox	Multi-core task execution
Signal Processing Toolbox	Signal analysis
Statistics and Machine Learning Toolbox	Data analysis, classification

All are installable via MPM on Linux:

```
products='MATLAB Curve_Fitting_Toolbox Instrument_Control_Toolbox
Optimization_Toolbox Parallel_Computing_Toolbox Signal_Processing_Toolbox
Statistics_and_Machine_Learning_Toolbox'
mpm install --release=R2025b --products=$products
```

2.3.2. Code Repository Structure

All CageLab code is version-controlled via Git, synced from Github (where we do main development) to Gitee (accessible from behind the Great Firewall). The Gitee repositories:

Table 2.2 – The Git Repositories

Repository	URL	Purpose
CageLab-Code	https://gitee.com/CogPlatform/CageLab-Code.git	Main CageLab codebase
Psychtoolbox	https://gitee.com/CogPlatform/Psychtoolbox.git	PTB-3 fork
opticka	https://gitee.com/CogPlatform/opticka.git	Core stimulus/task framework
matmoteGO	https://gitee.com/CogPlatform/matmoteGO.git	MATLAB ØMQ client
PTBSimia	https://gitee.com/CogPlatform/PTBSimia.git	Reward pump interface
matlab-jzmq	https://gitee.com/CogPlatform/matlab-jzmq.git	Java ØMQ bindings for MATLAB
PacmanTask	https://gitee.com/CogPlatform/PacmanTask.git	Task-specific code

Chapter 3

Network Setup

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CageLab requires reliable network connectivity between the Control-PC and all CageLab-Boxes. This chapter covers the three networking layers: NetBird VPN, SSH, and NoMachine remote desktop.

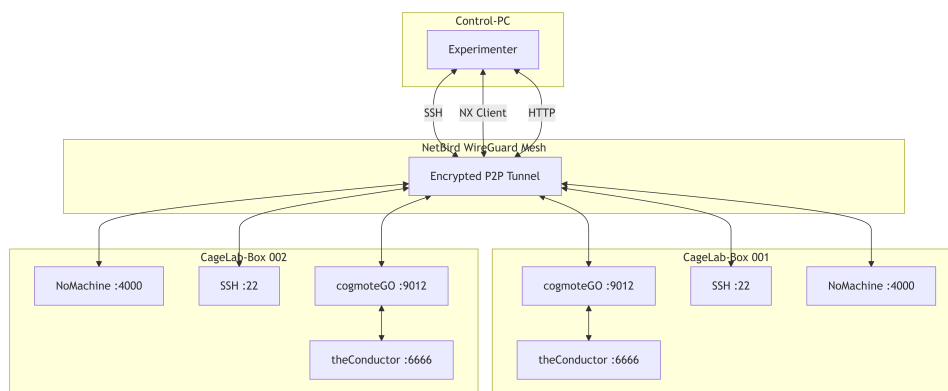


Figure 3.1 – Multi-CageLab communication

3.1. NetBird VPN

NetBird is a WireGuard-based mesh VPN that provides encrypted peer-to-peer connectivity. It is essential when CageLab-Boxes are on a different physical network from the Control-PC (e.g., separate lab networks or across institutions).

3.1.1. Installation

Install NetBird via the official APT repository (automated via Ansible playbook `install_netbird.yaml` or the bootstrap script):

```
curl -fsSL https://pkgs.netbird.io/install.sh | sh
```

3.1.2. Device Registration

Each device must be registered with your NetBird account using a setup key:

```
netbird up --setup-key YOUR_SETUP_KEY
```

The setup key can be stored as the environment variable `NETBIRD_SETUP_KEY` for automated provisioning via Ansible:

```
NETBIRD_SETUP_KEY=your-key ansible-playbook -l cagelab -K ansible/playbooks/
install_netbird.yaml
\index{Ansible!playbooks}
```

3.1.3. Managing the Mesh

- **View connected peers:** `netbird status`
- **Access a box via its NetBird IP:** Once connected, each box gets a stable VPN IP (e.g., `100.112.x.x` or IPv6 `fd00:1:1::x`), and a hostname like `cagelab-001.cloud.lab` reachable from any other peer in the mesh.

3.1.4. SSH Config (~/.ssh/config)

`makeLinks.sh` symlinks a pre-configured SSH config from `setup/config/sshconfig`. You MUST edit this to be relevant to your devices and network:

```
Host cagelab-001
  HostName cagelab-001.cloud.lab
  User cagelab
  IdentityFile ~/.ssh/cagelab
  IdentitiesOnly yes

Host cagelab-002
  HostName cagelab-002.cloud.lab
  User cagelab
  IdentityFile ~/.ssh/cagelab
  IdentitiesOnly yes
```

Naming convention: The `.ssh/config` and the ansible inventory file (`ansible/inventory/hosts`) defines several systems. Boxes accessed via DNS names (`*.cloud.lab`) are in groups like `cagelab`; boxes accessed via raw IPs have `i`-suffixed names (e.g., `cagelab-001i`). This dual-entry approach lets SSH/Ansible target the same box over different network paths if necessary, though you should prefer Netbird routes where possible.

3.2. SSH Configuration

SSH is the primary command-line interface to each CageLab-Box. Key-based authentication avoids password prompts.

3.2.1. Creating SSH Keys

SSH keys are more secure than using passwords, and also more convenient. There are two parts to a SSH key, a private and public key. The private key is kept ONLY on the Control-PC and must be kept private and not shared to unauthorised people. The public key should be installed on all CageLabs. On the Control-PC:

```
ssh-keygen -t ed25519 -f ~/.ssh/cagelab -C "cagelab-control"
ssh-copy-id -i ~/.ssh/cagelab.pub cagelab@<BOX-IP>
```

You should edit `/etc/ssh/sshd_config` to ensure only the Netbird IP is accepted using `ListenAddress`, and disable password access with `PasswordAuthentication no`.

3.2.2. Quick SSH Access

```
ssh cagelab-002 # via SSH config
ssh cagelab@192.168.3.22 -i ~/.ssh/cagelab # manual
```

3.3. NoMachine Remote Desktop

SSH is very powerful, however sometimes a desktop is required. NoMachine provides a high-performance remote desktop for GUI access to the CageLab-Box. It's useful for troubleshooting PTB rendering issues, configuring OBS, or inspecting the desktop state.

3.3.1. Installation

Via Ansible:

```
ansible-playbook -l cagelab -K ansible/playbooks/install_nomachine.yaml
```

Or manually:

```
curl -L -o /tmp/nomachine.deb https://web9001.nomachine.com/download/9.6/Linux/
nomachine_9.6.3_1_amd64.deb
sudo dpkg -i /tmp/nomachine.deb
```

Next you want to edit the `/usr/NX/etc/server.cfg` file and ensure only SSH key authentication is used, and the listen address is your secure IP address:

```
AcceptedAuthenticationMethods NX-private-key
NXdListenAddress 100.112.x.x
```

To set up the public SSH key, you can copy the SSH key you have already copied to CageLab to also serve login for NoMachine:

```
cp ~/.ssh/cagelab.pub .nx/config/authorized.crt
```

3.3.2. Connection

Use the NoMachine client (available on macOS, Windows, and Linux) and connect to the CageLab-Box's IP/hostname on port 4000, using the private part of the SSH key you set up. The LightDM autologin playbook (`install_lightdm_autologin.yaml`) ensures the desktop session starts automatically on boot.

Chapter 4

Using Ansible for Group Maintenance

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Ansible is an Infrastructure-as-Code tool that lets you run commands, deploy software, and enforce configuration across all your CageLab-Boxes simultaneously. This is essential when managing 5–50+ experimental rigs.

4.1. Setup

On the Control-PC:

```
uv tool install ansible
ansible-galaxy collection install ansible.posix
```

Then link the CageLab Ansible configuration:

```
~/Code/CageLab-Code/setup/makeLinks.sh -c
```

This symlinks `ansible.cfg` to `/etc/ansible/ansible.cfg` and the inventory to `/etc/ansible/hosts`.

4.2. The Inventory

The inventory (`ansible/inventory/hosts`) defines groups of CageLab-Boxes with their network addresses and SSH credentials, for our use for example:

Table 4.1 – Default groups

Group	Typical Use	Access Method
cagelab	Dev + production boxes	DNS (*.cloud.lab)
cagelab_ip	Same boxes, raw IPs	IP address
cagelab_songjiang	Songjiang lab boxes	DNS
cagelab_pacman	Pacman task boxes	DNS
cagelab_prisys	Primate Systems boxes	DNS
cagelab_test	Single test/dev box	DNS
admin	Control-PCs, admin hosts	DNS

Edit the inventory to match your own hosts and IPs. You can also add `mac_address` variables for Wake-on-LAN support.

4.3. Playbook Reference

All playbooks live in `ansible/playbooks/`. Run them with:

```
ansible-playbook -l <group> [-k] [-e "variable=value"] playbooks/<name>.yaml
```

Where: `-l <group>` limits execution to a specific inventory group - `-k` / `--ask-become-pass` prompts for the sudo password - `-e` passes extra variables

Table 4.2 – Ansible playbooks

Playbook	Purpose	Requires sudo
update.yaml	Full system update: repos, cogmoteGO, pixi, medi-amtx, OBS. Skips if task running.	Yes
reset_code.yaml	Force-reset all code repos to upstream HEAD (discards local changes).	No
check_api_status.yaml	Check if cogmoteGO reports a running task and show latest broadcast data.	No
services-start.yaml	Start all user systemd services.	Yes
services-stop.yaml	Stop all user systemd services.	Yes
chrony_slave.yaml	Configure NTP slave to a master clock. Set <code>chrony_master_ip</code> env var.	Yes
install_i3.yaml	Install i3 window manager.	Yes
install_lightdm_autologin.yaml	Install LightDM with autologin to i3.	Yes
install_netbird.yaml	Install NetBird VPN and optionally provision with setup key.	Yes
install_nomachine.yaml	Install latest NoMachine.	Yes
enable_wol.yaml	Enable Wake-on-LAN on all ethernet interfaces.	Yes
wol.yaml	Send WoL magic packet to wake specified group.	No
setup_matlab_startup.yaml	Configure MATLAB startup script.	No
upgrade-apt.yaml	APT package upgrade only.	Yes
apt_mirror.yaml	Switch APT to a specific mirror.	Yes

4.3.1. Example Commands

Full update on all CageLab boxes (asks for sudo password once):

```
ansible-playbook --limit cagelab --ask-become-pass playbooks/update.yaml
```

Check if any CageLab box is running a task:

```
ansible-playbook -l cagelab playbooks/check_api_status.yaml
```

Stop all services across all boxes:

```
ansible-playbook -l cagelab -K playbooks/services-stop.yaml
```

Wake all pacman boxes:

```
ansible-playbook -e "wol_group=cagelab_pacman" playbooks/wol.yaml
```

4.3.2. The Update Playbook in Detail

The `update.yaml` playbook is the most comprehensive. It:

1. Queries `cogmoteG0`'s status API — if a task is running, it skips the box.
2. Ensures `/usr/local/bin` is writable and home directory ownership is correct.
3. Updates APT cache if stale.
4. Force-pulls all 7 code repositories to latest HEAD (parallel async).
5. Runs `make_links.sh` to refresh symlinks.
6. Stops CageLab services.
7. Downloads and runs the `cogmoteG0` installer.
8. Updates `pixi` and its global packages.
9. Updates `mediamtx` via `eget`.
10. Updates OBS Studio via Flatpak.
11. Starts CageLab services.

The entire process is idempotent and safe to run regularly (e.g., weekly).

Chapter 5

Managing Running Services

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Each CageLab-Box runs several systemd user services that must be kept alive for the system to function. This chapter covers the service lifecycle: startup, monitoring, restarting, and stopping.

5.1. Service Architecture

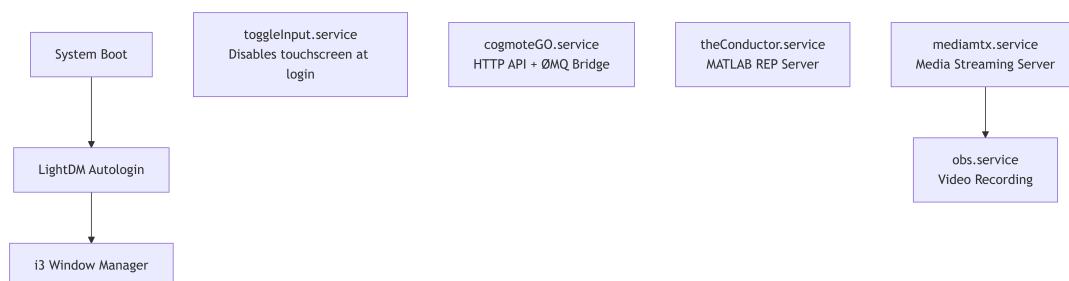


Figure 5.1 – Service relationships

5.2. Service List

Table 5.1 – The main services that run CageLab systems

Service	Type	Purpose	Startup Order
toggleInput.service	Oneshot	Disables touchscreen during boot to prevent subject interaction with OS	1st
cogmoteGO.service	Simple	HTTP API and ØMQ bridge on :9012	2nd
theConductor.service	Simple	MATLAB-based REP server that runs behavioural tasks	3rd
mediamtx.service	Simple	RTSP/WebRTC media server for video streaming	4th
obs.service	Simple	OBS Studio for session video recording	5th

5.3. Convenience Scripts

CageLab provides ZSH convenience scripts in `~/bin/` (symlinked from `scripts/`):

Table 5.2 – CageLab scripts

Script	Action
cagelab-start	[Re]start all services (toggleInput → cogmoteGO → theConductor → mediamtx → obs)
cagelab-stop	Stop all services in reverse order
cagelab-reset	Stop + daemon-reload + restart cogmoteGO and theConductor; disable touchscreen
cagelab-reset-services	Full service reset: disable old, re-link from repo, re-enable
cagelab-reset-code	Force-reset all code repositories to latest upstream
cagelab-reset-OBS	Stop + restart OBS and mediamtx (for streaming issues)
cagelab-status	Check if cogmoteGO is running and show latest broadcast data
cagelab-update	Full update: stop services → reset code → update cogmoteGO/pixi/mediamtx/flatpak → restart
cagelab-monitor	Launch tmuxp session with CPU monitor + journalctl for cogmoteGO and theConductor

5.3.1. Usage Examples

```
# Quick restart of core services
cagelab-reset

# Full update after code changes
cagelab-update

# Check if everything is running
cagelab-status

# Monitor logs and CPU in real time
cagelab-monitor
```

5.4. Manual systemctl Commands

For fine-grained control, use `systemctl --user:`

Table 5.3 – tmux keyboard commands

Keystroke	Action
Ctrl-a s	Show session list
Ctrl-a -	Split vertically
Ctrl-a \	Split horizontally
Ctrl-a x	Kill pane (confirm with y)
Ctrl-a d	Detach from session
Ctrl-a arrow	Navigate panes

The tmuxp config is at `~/.config/tmuxp/cagelab-monitor.yaml` and is symlinked by `makelinks.sh`.

5.6. touchscreen Management

The `toggleInput` script enables or disables touchscreen devices via `xinput`. This is critical: subjects must not interact with the OS desktop.

```
toggleInput disable          # disable default device (ILITEK-TP)
toggleInput enable           # enable default device
toggleInput disable ILITEK-TP # disable specific device
toggleInput enable "Touchpad" # enable specific device
```

`toggleInput.service` runs at boot to disable the touchscreen. Tasks re-enable it when needed, and `cagelab-reset` disables it afterwards.

5.7. OBS Recording Control

OBS Studio recording can be controlled via its WebSocket API using the `control-OBS.py` script:

```
# Start recording
python3 ~/Code/CageLab-Code/scripts/control-OBS.py start --password YOUR_WS_PASS

# Stop recording
python3 ~/Code/CageLab-Code/scripts/control-OBS.py stop

# Toggle recording
python3 ~/Code/CageLab-Code/scripts/control-OBS.py toggle

# Check status
python3 ~/Code/CageLab-Code/scripts/control-OBS.py status

# Control remote OBS via SSH tunnel
python3 ~/Code/CageLab-Code/scripts/control-OBS.py status \
    --ssh-host cagelab-001.cloud.lab --ssh-user cagelab
```

The password can be set via the `OBS_WS_PASSWORD` environment variable.

5.8. Data Management: cagepush and cagepull

Two powerful ZSH scripts handle data and file transfer between the Control-PC and CageLab-Boxes:

5.8.1. cagepush — Push Code to Boxes

```
# Force push CageLab code from Control-PC to cagelab-001 box (uses rsync with delete)
cagepush -s cagelab-001.cloud.lab ~/Code/CageLab-Code
```



```
# Push multiple projects to multiple hosts in parallel
cagepush -j 4 -s cagelab-001.cloud.lab -s cagelab-002.cloud.lab \
  ~/Code/CageLab-Code ~/Code/opticka
```

```
# Dry run (no actual transfer)
cagepush -n -s cagelab-001.cloud.lab ~/Code/CageLab-Code
```

5.8.2. *cagepull* — Retrieve Data from Boxes

```
# Pull saved data from all boxes to local directory
cagepull -l ~/data -s cagelab-001.cloud.lab -s cagelab-002.cloud.lab \
  ~/OptickaFiles/SavedData
```

```
# Parallel pull with 4 concurrent transfers
cagepull -j 4 -l ~/experiment-data -s cagelab@cagelab-001 OptickaData
```

Both scripts use *rsync* over SSH with robust retry, progress reporting, *--mkpath* auto-detection, and optional dry-run mode.

Chapter 6

Using the CageLab GUI

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The CageLab GUI is the experimenter's primary interface for designing experiments, connecting to boxes, and monitoring sessions. It runs inside MATLAB on the Control-PC.

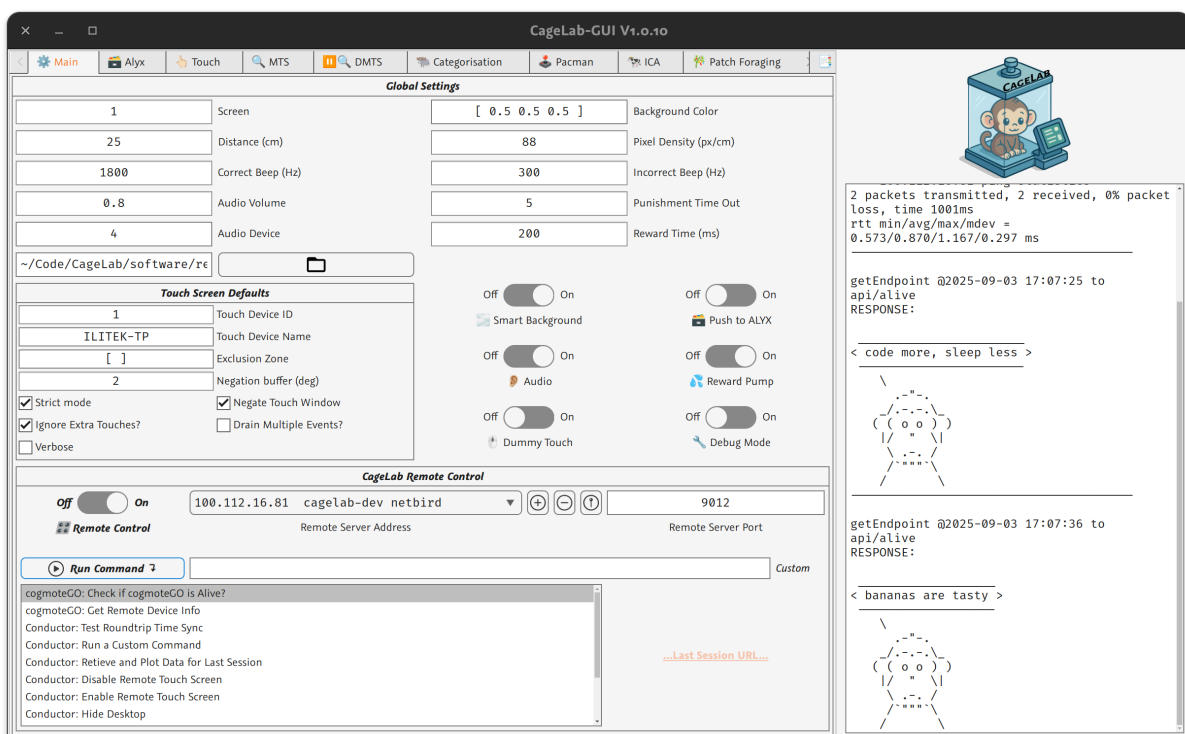


Figure 6.1 – Main CageLab GUI

6.1. GUI Overview

The GUI has several functional areas:

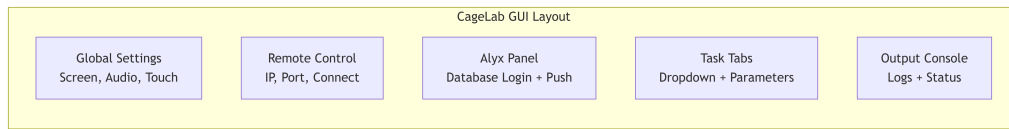


Figure 6.2 – GUI Panels

6.1.1. Remote Control

- **IP Address:** IP or hostname of the CageLab-Box
- **Port:** ØMQ port (default: the port `cogmoteG0` is bound to)
- **Connect / Disconnect:** Establish or tear down the ØMQ connection
- **Test Timing:** Sends a `gettime` command to measure round-trip latency

6.1.2. Task Selector

Selects which behavioural task to run. See [CageLab Tasks] for details on each task. Parameters specific to the selected task appear dynamically, allowing you to configure:

- Stimulus type (disc, picture, shape)
- Sizes, positions, timing
- Distractor count
- Trial parameters

6.1.3. Session Info

Metadata about the experimental session:

- **Subject Name:** Animal/subject identifier
- **Researcher:** Name of the experimenter
- **Lab:** Lab name/location
- **Procedure:** Standard operating procedure
- **Project:** Research project identifier
- **Task Protocol:** Experiment-specific protocol

This metadata is embedded in saved data files and optionally pushed to the Alyx database.

6.1.4. Alyx Integration

See the separate Alyx Guide (`docs/Alyx-Guide.md`) for full details. The GUI panel enables:

1. Login to the Alyx database
2. Query subjects, sessions, and projects
3. Push session metadata and data files via Minio S3

Session Information:	
guiyi	CognitionPlatform
Subject ID 	Lab Name 
Ian	cagelab-002
Researcher 	Experiment Location 
Behavior training/... ▼	Test-Training ▼
Procedure	Project
Cerebral cortex ▼	
Brain Region	Task Protocol

Figure 6.3 – Alyx Session Setup

6.2. Running an Experiment

1. **Connect:** Enter the CageLab-Box IP/port and click Connect.
2. **Configure:** Select a task, adjust parameters, fill in session info.
3. **Start:** Click “Run Task”. The GUI sends a JSON `{"command":"cltasks.startXxx","data":{...}}` message via ØMQ.
4. **Monitor:** The output console shows log messages. Status updates appear in the status bar.
5. **Stop:** Click “Stop Task” or wait for the task to complete. Data is saved to `~/optickafiles/savedata/` on the CageLab-Box.

6.3. Advanced Features

6.3.1. Multiple Box Control

A single CageLab GUI can connect to many CageLab-Boxes simultaneously. Each connection is independent — you can start a task on Box 1, configure a task on Box 2, and monitor both.

6.3.2. Desktop Control Commands

Via theConductor’s command interface, the GUI can:

Table 6.1 – Remote commands

Command	Effect
hidedesktop	Hide the OS desktop (shows solid colour) to prevent subject distraction
showdesktop	Restore the OS desktop
disablesleep	Prevent display sleep/power saving
enablesleep	Re-enable normal display power management
rundemo	Run PTB VBLSyncTest for timing verification

6.3.3. Timing Verification

The `gettime` command performs a round-trip timing test:

1. Sends `GetSecs` value from Control-PC
2. `theConductor` returns its own `GetSecs` and system time
3. Differences reveal network latency and clock drift

Chapter 7

Using Alyx with CageLab

#minitoc

Alyx is an experiment database made by International Brain Lab. While Alyx is mostly focused on neuroscience tasks in mice, it can be generalised to other species as it supports generic JSON fields, and the core structure across species is more similar than the differences anyway. We use TWO services:

- Alyx database — register subjects, labs, experimenters, projects and tasks; each time a session is run record the experiment metadata and link to the binary experiment files.
- S3 data store (**Minio** server) — copy raw binary and text experiment files saved by each session linked to the Alyx session metadata. Searching in Alyx can recover the files saved in the S3 data store.

In the CageLab GUI there are two main interactions with Alyx:

- 1) Login / query the database. Not linked to an experiment session.
- 2) Setup session data and enable CageLab to add the session to the database. The session is added by the remote system, not the control computer.

7.1. BEFORE STARTING: Setting up the Database



You **MUST** ensure the Alyx database is setup with the core items you will use to run the session:
Subjects, Users, Labs, Locations, Projects

Home > Subject admin > Subjects

Select subject to change

Search 6 results (Clear search)

Action: ----- Go 0 of 6 selected

	NICKNAME	2	WEIGHT %	BIRTH DATE	1	SEX	ALIVE	# SESS	RESPONSIBLE USER	LAB
☐	guiyi	-	-			M	✓	0	Jiahao	CognitionPlatform
☐	guanguan	-	-			M	✓	0	Jiahao	CognitionPlatform
☐	Cosmos	-	-			U	✓	1	Jiahao	CognitionPlatform
☐	TestSubject	-		March 1, 2023		F	✓	100	Ian	CognitionPlatform

Figure 7.1 – alt text

Before running any sessions, ensure that the items you will use exist in the Alyx database, login to your Alyx web interface (e.g. <http://172.16.102.30:8000>) and edit the database to add the Subjects, the Users (Researcher), the Lab, and the Projects the sessions will be linked to.

7.2. CageLab: (1) Logging in and running queries

CageLab allows you to enter your Alyx IP/port and user name and then login:

http://172.16.102.30:8000 Ian

ALYX IP & Port ALYX User

Login Log out

Figure 7.2 – Alyx IP address

There is also a place to enter the Data repo IP and the data repo (bucket) name, and also to be able to edit the Alyx login password and data repo keys:

http://172.16.102.77:90 cognitionplatform

Alyx Data Repository URL Alyx Data-Repository Name

New Alyx Password Change PW

Figure 7.3 – Data repo



These details are stored using MATLAB's `getSecret` and `setSecret` functions and are stored on the local, not remote machine. The remote machine can be set up with its own secrets or when a session runs the local secrets are sent to the remote system at runtime.

Once logged in you will see the query panel become active:

Figure 7.4 – Logged In

Note that you are logged in from your computer. This is nothing to do with a remote cagelab. By logging in it allows you to run Alyx database queries, for example `sessions?subject=TestSubject` will return all sessions recorded by Alyx for subject `TestSubject`:

id	subject	start_time
b691b35-b3ab-4a11-b923-59b830a7806	TestSubject	2025-12-19T03:15:01
689b866a-587b-4f56-8a06-a724a36b7b7b	TestSubject	2025-12-15T10:28:19
81bb888c-8c91-4c03-bada-7667e65ba7	TestSubject	2025-12-12T12:14:31
7ed7d5dd-f2a4-4bdc-8a2d-398d6baa87b7b	TestSubject	2025-12-11T14:32:54
4bd3d57f-3980-4072-a994-264c06f04001	TestSubject	2025-12-10T18:30:23
cbab63db-4b11-4b3f-a381-ed0e9a73f521	TestSubject	2025-09-09T18:25:3
144f1b3-6665-4943-844e-934f657e99f1	TestSubject	2025-09-09T17:35:1
841d5b79-5544-4e8c-847e-143a6c0b2a75	TestSubject	2025-09-09T17:32:5
7a739df9-fd5d-4451-91cc-39f8b6b6c45d4	TestSubject	2025-09-09T16:30:1

Figure 7.5 – Query 1

... or for example the lab locations where experiments are run:

name	lab	json
Room-420	CognitionPlatform	
Songjiang-01	CognitionPlatform	
Room-412	CognitionPlatform	
pacman-001	CognitionPlatform	1x1 struct
cagelab-002	CognitionPlatform	1x1 struct
cagelab-001	CognitionPlatform	1x1 struct
cagelab-003	CognitionPlatform	1x1 struct
cagelab-004	CognitionPlatform	1x1 struct
cagelab-005	CognitionPlatform	1x1 struct
cagelab-dev	CognitionPlatform	1x1 struct
pacman-002	CognitionPlatform	1x1 struct
pacman-003	CognitionPlatform	1x1 struct

Figure 7.6 – Query 2

A full list of all the queries you can perform is available from the Alyx database itself: <http://172.16.102.30:8000/docs/>

7.3. CageLab: (2) Running a Session

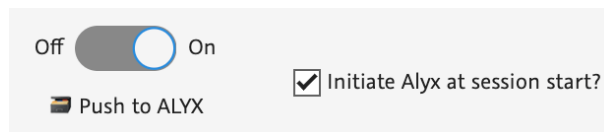


Figure 7.7 – Enable Alyx

When you use CageLab GUI, turn ON push to Alyx. You can also “initiate” Alyx at session start so that Alyx logs a session once it initiates (otherwise it will only register after it is manually ended, thus a crash would not show in Alyx and data be lost).

Then ensure your Session data is accurate and consistent with what is in the database:

Figure 7.8 – Session

Subject, Lab, User and Location MUST already exist in Alyx or else it will crash. Procedure, Project, Brain Region should also be valid (they are populated after logging in to ensure they are valid). Task protocol is optional.

When you run the task, Alyx will be initiated with a new Session, and when the session is stopped / ends, the MAT and LOG files will be uploaded to the S3 data server. You can check in the Sessions view:

Home > Action admin > Sessions

Select session to change

Search 105 results (Clear search)

Action: ----- Go 0 of 50 selected

	SUBJECT	START TIME	1	NUMBER	LAB	3	# DATASETS	TASK PROTOCOL	2	QC	USERS	PROJECT
☐	TestSubject	Dec. 19, 2025, 3:15 a.m.	1		CognitionPlatform		2			PASS	Ian	Things-Training
☐	TestSubject	Dec. 15, 2025, 10:28 a.m.	1		CognitionPlatform		2			PASS	Ian	Things-Training
☐	TestSubject	Dec. 12, 2025, 12:14 p.m.	1		CognitionPlatform		-			PASS	Ian	Things-Training

Figure 7.9 – Sessions

You will see the session and can confirm that datasets were added. Note the data also remains in the same local SavedData folder, so it is available even if there is a database crash or other problem.

Chapter 8

CageLab Tasks

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CageLab provides a library of behavioural tasks in the `+cltasks` package. Each task function is self-contained, following a standard pattern: initialise hardware, build stimuli, run a trial loop, log data, and clean up.

8.1. Task Architecture

All tasks share a common structure:

1. **Input parsing:** `clutil.checkInput(in)` validates and normalises parameters.
2. **Initialisation:** `clutil.initialise()` sets up `screenManager`, `audioManager`, `rewardManager`, `touchManager`, and logging.
3. **Stimulus construction:** Build `opticka` stimulus objects (`imageStimulus`, `discStimulus`, `metaStimulus`).
4. **Trial loop:** `while r.keepRunning ... end` — the core experiment logic.
5. **Data logging:** `clutil.updateTrialResult()` saves per-trial data.
6. **Cleanup:** `clutil.endTask()` closes hardware, saves final data, and optionally uploads to Alyx.

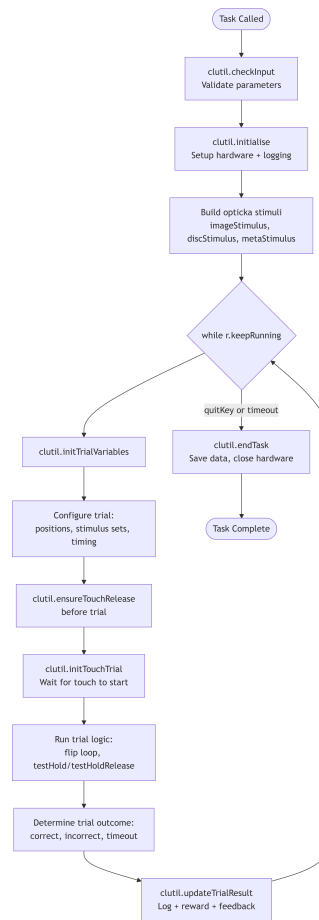


Figure 8.1 – General Trial Loop

8.2. Task Catalog

8.2.1. Touch Training (startTouchTraining)

The foundational task for teaching subjects to interact with the touchscreen. Uses an automated progressive shaping procedure through multiple phases:

Table 8.1 – Touch training

Phase Range	Parameter Shaped	Description
1–15	Size	Stimulus decreases from <code>maxSize</code> to <code>minSize</code>
16–20	Position	Stimulus appears at increasingly eccentric positions (3°, 5°, 7°, 11°)
21–32	Hold time	Required touch duration increases from 10ms to 400ms
33+	Release	Subject must touch, hold, then release; release window tightens from 3s to 1s

Parameters:

Table 8.2 – Touch parameters

Parameter	Default	Description
stimulus	'Picture'	'Picture' (flowers) or 'Disc'
fg	[0 0 0]	Stimulus foreground colour
minSize	2°	Minimum stimulus diameter
maxSize	10°	Maximum stimulus diameter
trialTime	5s	Maximum trial duration
easyMode	0	If 1, only first 20 phases (no hold/release)

8.2.2. Match-to-Sample (startMatchToSample)

A classic delayed match-to-sample (DMTS) or delayed non-match-to-sample (DNMTS) task. The subject views a sample stimulus, then after a delay must choose the matching (or non-matching) stimulus from an array of distractors.

Variants:

Table 8.3 – Match-to-sample variants

Variant	Description
MTS	Sample + distractors shown simultaneously; touch the matching one
DMTS	Sample shown, then delay, then distractors appear; touch the matching one
DNMTS	Sample shown, then delay, then distractors appear; touch the <i>non-matching</i> one

Parameters:

Table 8.4 – MTS parameters

Parameter	Default	Description
object	'fractals'	Stimulus category: 'fractals', 'quaddles', or 'flowers'
objectSize	10°	Stimulus diameter
objectSep	15°	Separation between stimuli
sampleY	0°	Vertical position of sample
distractorY	-10°	Vertical position of distractors
distractorN	2	Number of distractors (1–4)
sampleTime	1.0s	Sample viewing duration (scalar or [min max] range)
delayTime	1.0s	Delay between sample and choice (scalar or [min max] range)
delayDistractors	true	Show distractors during delay period
trialTime	5.0s	Maximum response window
targetHoldTime	0.2s	Required touch duration

Training mode: When taskType contains 'training', only one stimulus is shown (no distractors), hold time requirements are relaxed, and the delay is set to zero.

8.2.3. Intra/Extra-Dimensional Set Shifting (startIED)

Based on the CANTAB IED task, this measures cognitive flexibility and attentional set-shifting. Subjects learn to discriminate stimuli based on one dimension (e.g., shape) while ignoring another (e.g., colour), then must shift attention when the rule changes.

Stage Sequence (standard CANTAB order):

Table 8.5 – IED Types

Stage	Code	Description
Simple Discrimination	sd	Two shapes; learn which is rewarded
Compound Discrimination	cd	Shapes + colours added; shape remains relevant
Simple Reversal	sr	Same shapes; reward contingency reverses
Compound Reversal	cr	Same compound; reward contingency reverses
Intra-Dimensional Shift	ids	New exemplars; shape still relevant
Intra-Dimensional Reversal	idr	Same as IDS; contingency reverses
Extra-Dimensional Shift	eds	New exemplars; relevant dimension switches to <i>colour</i>
Extra-Dimensional Reversal	edr	Same as EDS; contingency reverses

Parameters:

Table 8.6 – IED parameters

Parameter	Default	Description
taskType	'cd'	Stage code (see table above)
objectSize	10°	Stimulus size
objectSep	15°	Separation between left/right targets
sampleY	0°	Vertical position
trialTime	5.0s	Response window
targetHoldTime	0.2s	Touch hold requirement

Stimuli: 6 unique shapes (circle, rect, triangle, heptagon, star, random) × 6 colours (red, green, blue, yellow, magenta, cyan), randomly paired per session.

8.2.4. Visual Oddball (startVisualOddball)

A simple go/no-go task: subjects respond to rare “deviant” stimuli and withhold response to frequent “standard” stimuli.

Parameters:

Table 8.7 – Visual Oddball parameters

Parameter	Default	Description
deviantProbability	0.2	Proportion of deviant trials
objectSize	8°	Standard stimulus size
deviantSize	8°	Deviant stimulus size
stimulus	'Disc'	'Disc' or 'Picture'
standardColour	[1 1 1]	RGB of standard (white)
deviantColour	[1 0 0]	RGB of deviant (red)
standardShape	'circle'	Shape name for picture mode
deviantShape	'triangle2'	Shape name for picture mode

8.2.5. Odd-One-Out / Things Task (startThings)

A visual oddity detection task. Three stimuli are shown; two are identical, one is different. The subject must touch the odd stimulus.

Parameters:

Table 8.8 – Things Task parameters

Parameter	Default	Description
objectSize	10°	Stimulus size
objectSep	15°	Separation between stimuli
distractorSpreadAngle	0°	Angular spread for polar layout (0° = horizontal line)
distractorCenterAngle	270°	Center angle for polar layout (270° = upward)
pedestalOpacity	varies	Highlight opacity for the odd target (training aid)
trialTime	5.0s	Response window

8.2.6. Drag Categorisation (startDragCategorisation)

A touch-and-drag task where subjects must move a stimulus to one of two target locations, testing categorisation or spatial matching.

8.2.7. IED Morphobes Variants

startIEDmorphobes and startIEDmorphobes4D extend the IED task with morphed stimulus continua, allowing parametric control of stimulus similarity. The 4D variant operates across four stimulus dimensions.

8.3. The theConductor Command API

theConductor exposes the following commands via ØMQ. These are used internally by the CageLab GUI but can also be sent programmatically:

Table 8.9 – Loop commands

Command	Data Required	Response	Description
<code>request('command', 'functionName', 'targeting_command', {...})</code>		<code>targeting_reply</code>	Execute a MATLAB function/command
<code>rundemo</code>	none	<code>demo_run</code>	Run PTB VBLSyncTest demo
<code>echo</code>	any	<code>echo_reply</code>	Echo back received data
<code>gettime</code>	<code>struct('GetSecs', value)</code>	<code>timesync_reply</code>	Round-trip timing test
<code>status</code>	none	<code>Processing</code>	Check if server is alive
<code>getlastrun</code>	none	<code>taskdata</code>	Retrieve <code>lastTaskRun.mat</code>
<code>commandlist</code>	none	List of commands	Get available commands
<code>syncbuffer</code>	<code>struct('frameSize', N)</code>	<code>syncbuffer_ack</code>	Set ØMQ frame size
<code>enablesleep</code>	none	<code>enable-sleep</code>	Enable display power saving
<code>disablesleep</code>	none	<code>disable-sleep</code>	Disable display power saving
<code>hidedesktop</code>	none	<code>hide-desktop</code>	Hide OS desktop
<code>showdesktop</code>	none	<code>show-desktop</code>	Show OS desktop
<code>exittask</code>	none	<code>invalid</code>	(only valid during task execution)
<code>exit/quit</code>	none	<code>bye</code>	Shut down command loop
<code>exitmatlab</code>	none	<code>bye</code>	Shut down loop and quit MATLAB

8.4. cogmoteGO HTTP API

cogmoteGO exposes a REST API on port 9012:

Table 8.10 – REST API endpoints

Endpoint	Method	Purpose
/api/health	GET	Health check
/api/status	GET	Get running status + task info
/api/cmds/proxies	POST	Register a new command proxy
/api/cmds/proxies	GET	List all proxies
/api/cmds/proxies/<name>	DELETE	Remove a proxy
/api/broadcast/data/default/latest	GET	Get latest broadcasted task data

Chapter 9

Troubleshooting

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This chapter covers common issues and their solutions.

9.1. Service Issues

9.1.1. cogmoteGO Won't Start

Symptom: `systemctl --user status cogmoteGO` shows failed or inactive.

Solutions:

```
# Check logs for error details
journalctl --user -u cogmoteGO.service -n 50 --no-pager

# Common fix: reset and reinstall
cagelab-stop
cogmoteGO service -u          # remove old service file
cogmoteGO service             # reinstall
systemctl --user daemon-reload
cagelab-start
```

9.1.2. theConductor Won't Start

Symptom: `systemctl --user status theConductor` shows failed.

Solutions:

```
# Check for MATLAB path issues
journalctl --user -u theConductor.service -n 100 --no-pager

# Verify MATLAB is installed and licensed
/usr/local/MATLAB/R2025b/bin/matlab -nodesktop -nosplash -r "exit"

# Verify ØMQ Java library
ls ~/Code/matlab-jzmq/

# Try manual start to see errors
cd ~/Code/CageLab-Code
matlab -nodesktop -nosplash -r "tc=theConductor('runNow',true);"
```

9.1.3. Service Dependencies Fail

The services start in a specific order. If one fails, subsequent services may also fail:

1. toggleInput should complete (oneshot)
2. cogmoteG0 must be healthy (check: `curl http://localhost:9012/api/health`)
3. theConductor registers with cogmoteG0 via HTTP API
4. mediamtx binds to media ports
5. obs connects to mediamtx

Use `cagelab-status` to verify the chain:

```
cagelab-status
# Should print: "CageLab service is running." plus broadcast data
```

9.2. Network Issues

9.2.1. Cannot SSH to Box

Solutions:

1. Verify the box is powered on (try WoL: `ansible-playbook -e "wol_group=cagelab" playbooks/wol.yaml`)
2. Check NetBird connectivity: `netbird status`
3. Try both hostname and IP
4. Verify SSH key is correct: `ssh -vv cagelab@box-ip`

9.2.2. ØMQ Connection Fails

Symptom: CageLab GUI cannot connect to CageLab-Box.

Solutions:

1. Verify cogmoteG0 is running on the box: `ssh box-host cagelab-status`
2. Check port accessibility: `nc -zv box-host 9012`
3. Check firewall: `sudo ufw status`
4. If using NetBird, ensure the VPN is up: `netbird status`

9.3. Task Issues

9.3.1. Task Crashes Mid-Session

Symptom: Task stops unexpectedly; data may be incomplete.

Data recovery: theConductor saves `~/lastTaskRun.mat` after each trial. The `getlastrun` command retrieves this:

```
% From MATLAB (via CageLab GUI's "Get Last Run" button)
```

Full session data is saved to `~/optickafiles/savedata/<date>/<subject>_<task>_<timestamp>/` and includes:

- `*.mat` — full MATLAB workspace
- `*.log` — text log of all events
- `info.json` — session metadata

9.3.2. Touchscreen Not Responding

Solutions:

```
# Check if touchscreen is disabled
xinput list | grep -i ilitek

# Enable it
toggleInput enable ILITEK-TP

# Verify it works
xinput test <device-id> # touch the screen; should see events
```

9.3.3. OBS Streaming Fails

```
# Check OBS status
systemctl --user status obs.service

# Restart OBS and MediaMTX
cagelab-reset-OBS

# Check OBS logs
journalctl --user -u obs.service -n 50

# Manually control recording
python3 ~/Code/CageLab-Code/scripts/control-OBS.py status --host 127.0.0.1
```

9.4. Display Issues

9.4.1. PTB Sync Failures

Symptom: PTB reports “Synchronization failure” or dropped frames.

Solutions:

1. **Ensure i3 is running** — GNOME/KDE compositors cause sync issues
2. **Disable display power saving:**

```
xset s off -dpms
```

3. Set performance power profile:

```
powerprofilesctl set performance
```

4. Check display mode: Use `xrandr` to verify refresh rate matches PTB expectations

5. Run diagnostic: Use the `rundemo` command from CageLab GUI to run PTB's VBLSyncTest

9.5. Log Locations

Table 9.1 – Log locations

Log	Location
cogmoteGO	<code>journalctl --user -u cogmoteGO.service</code>
theConductor	<code>journalctl --user -u theConductor.service</code>
Task logs	<code>~/optickafiles/savedata/<date>/<session>/*.log</code>
OBS logs	<code>journalctl --user -u obs.service</code>
Task Starts	<code>~/cagelab-start.txt</code>
System logs	<code>journalctl</code> or <code>dmesg</code>
Task errors	Messages appended to <code>~/cagelab-start.txt</code>

Appendix A

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A.1. File and Directory Layout

```
~/Code/
├─ CageLab-Code/           # Main CageLab repository
│   ├── +cltasks/         # Behavioural task functions
│   ├── +clutil/          # Shared utility functions
│   ├── ansible/          # Ansible playbooks and inventory
│   ├── docs/             # Documentation and images
│   ├── scripts/          # ZSH convenience scripts
│   ├── services/         # systemd unit files
│   ├── setup/            # Bootstrap and configuration
│   │   ├── bootstrap.sh  # Initial machine setup
│   │   ├── makelinks.sh  # Symlink management
│   │   └─ config/        # Config files (zsh, i3, tmux, ssh, etc.)
│   └─ theConductor.m      # ØMQ REP server class
├─ Psychtoolbox/          # Psychtoolbox-3
├─ opticka/               # Core stimulus/task framework
├─ matmoteGO/             # MATLAB ØMQ client
├─ PTBSimia/              # Hardware interfaces (reward pumps)
├─ matlab-jzmq/           # Java ØMQ bindings
└─ PacmanTask/            # Task-specific code

~/bin/                    # Symlinks to scripts/*.sh
~/.config/systemd/user/   # Symlinks to services/*.service
~/.config/tmuxp/          # tmuxp configuration
```

```
~/.config/rsync-excludes # rsync exclusion patterns
~/.ssh/config             # SSH configuration (symlinked)
```

A.2. systemd Service Dependency Graph

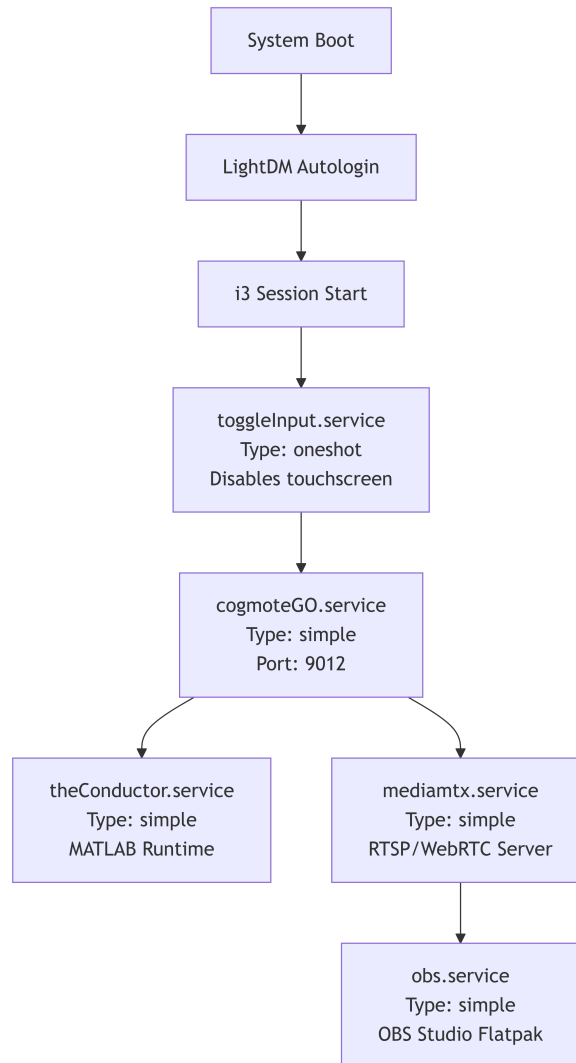


Figure A.1 – systemd boot dependencies

A.3. Network Port Reference

Table A.1 – Ports used

Port	Service	Protocol	Purpose
22	SSH	TCP	Secure shell access
4000	NoMachine NX	TCP	Remote desktop
6666	theConductor	ØMQ (internal)	REP server bound port
9012	cogmoteGO	HTTP	REST API + command bridge
8554	MediaMTX	TCP	RTSP streaming
8889	MediaMTX	TCP	WebRTC signalling
8189	MediaMTX	UDP	WebRTC ICE
4455	OBS Studio	TCP	WebSocket control API
51820	NetBird	UDP	WireGuard tunnel

A.4. Key Environment Variables

Table A.2 – ENV vars

Variable	Purpose
NETBIRD_SETUP_KEY	Provision new NetBird peers
OBS_WS_PASSWORD	OBS WebSocket authentication
chrony_master_ip	NTP master for chrony_slave playbook
DISPLAY	X11 display target (usually :0)
XDG_RUNTIME_DIR	systemd user session runtime

A.5. CageLab Version History

Table A.3 – Versions

Version	Date	Key Changes
1.0.70	2025-07	Test fixes, SSH config updates
1.0.0	2025-Q1	Initial stable release

A.6. Further Reading

- **opticka Framework:** github.com/iandol/opticka
- **Psychtoolbox-3:** psychtoolbox.org/ 
- **ZeroMQ Guide:** zguide.zeromq.org/
- **Ansible Documentation:** docs.ansible.com/
- **NetBird Docs:** docs.netbird.io/
- **NoMachine:** www.nomachine.com/
- **MediaMTX:** github.com/bluenviro/mediamtx
- **OBS Studio:** obsproject.com/

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